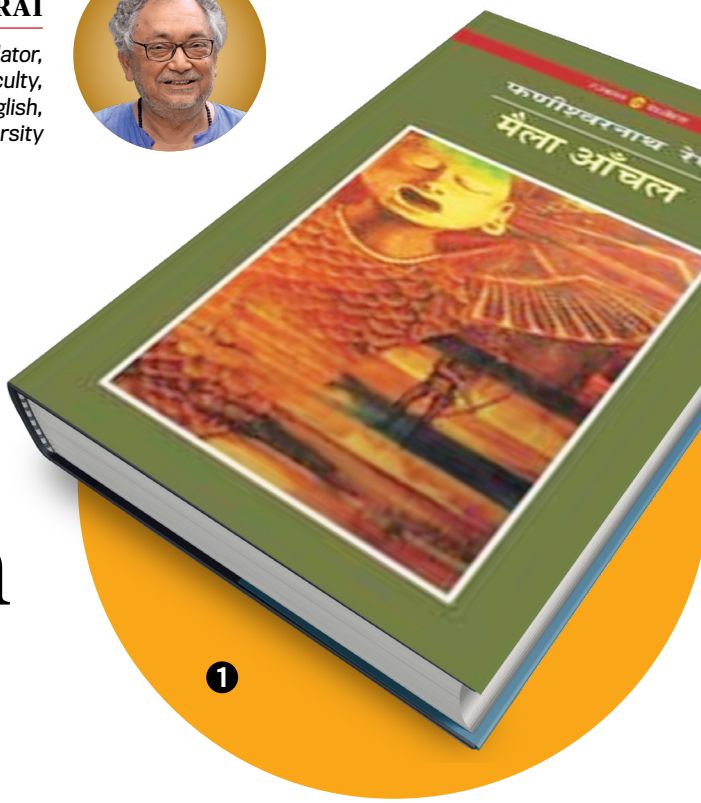
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Chroniclers Of The Nation's Pain

The modern Hindi novel embodies the long shadow of Partition, post-Independence disillusionment, political upheaval and the realities of caste



The novel is perpetually, globally, a-dying—even as it continues to thrive. The lugubriousness of this funerary expectation is compounded in the case of the Hindi novel. Hindi has, for reasons deriving from the circumstances of its modern invention, acquired an exaggerated sense of its historical destiny: *rashtrabhasha*, no less, charged with the responsibility of making the 'nation'. Then there is the burden of an implacable, undeniable social reality that demands—more, commands—address. It is a wonder that novelists still find the creative energy to tell stories.

It is also remarkable that there is little echo of the euphoria of Independence—of *azaadi*, to use a word that has oddly become charged with subversive meaning—in the years after that famously mottled dawn—*yeh dagh dagh ujaala*.... To find any suggestion of that moment of hope and idealism, one is forced to turn to the Bombay cinema of the 1950s. Evidently, the 'longer view' of literature did not permit that illusion. Unsurprisingly, the theme of Partition, which came twinned with Independence, is explored by some of the major texts to which we return. Yashpal's *Jhoota Sach* (1960), published in two parts, is an extended novel-length treatment of the trauma of Partition, rendered poignant against the meticulously rendered backdrop of community in 'Bholapandhe Gali' in pre-1947 Lahore. The stories of Manto and Rajinder Singh Bedi are well-known and Agyeya's collection, *Sharanarthi*, deserves to be better known, but Yashpal's novel is a prime exemplar and a far cry from the gory melodrama more typical of this genre. Rahi Masoom Raza's *Aadha Gaon* (1966) is located far from the violent borders, in east UP, and explores, with wit and colour, the fracturing of the rural community of Gangauli in the context of Partition. Bhisham Sahni's *Tamas* (1974) revisited Partition territory after a significant lapse of time. It tells a familiar story, but the fact that it aroused so much resentment showed that the social tendencies that produced the Partition of 1947 were still around, still "unfinished business".

It is difficult to accommodate Krishna Sobti in any one category, but in many of her writings, there are subtle signs, whether of the multiple partitions that have already happened or of those that are still to come. The relatively staid (and largely male, certainly patriarchal) Hindi establish-